IGA IN CONTEXT

Identity Governance and Administration (IGA) appeared in the mid-2000s as organizations struggled to manage user accounts, entitlements, and compliance requirements across an increasing number of systems. Traditional identity management tools could create and delete accounts, but they lacked processes for continuous oversight, making it difficult to determine who has access to what, and why.

IGA filled that gap by combining identity administration (the provisioning and deprovisioning of accounts) with governance capabilities such as certification campaigns, separation-of-duties checks, and audit reporting. Gartner popularized the term in its early reports on identity governance frameworks, describing IGA as the foundation for ensuring that access remains appropriate, compliant, and reviewable throughout the identity lifecycle.

Over time, IGA evolved from a compliance function into an operational discipline. Modern platforms like SailPoint, Saviynt, and Oracle Identity Governance automate entitlement management, access requests, and periodic reviews across both on-premises and cloud environments. Many of these platforms align with NIST SP 800-53 controls for access management and accountability.

In modern architectures, IGA operates alongside access management (authentication and session control) and policy governance (runtime authorization):

- IGA governs who can be assigned access.
- Policy governance governs how access is granted or denied in real time.

Together, they create the assurance framework that keeps authorization aligned with organizational policy and regulatory expectations—turning identity data and access decisions into a coherent, auditable system of control.